

Real-world insights on biosimilar conversion following adalimumab originator product formulary exclusion in treatment-experienced patients



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Background

Increasing availability of biosimilars offers an opportunity to improve patient access to medications, while maintaining efficacy and reducing total cost of care. Adalimumab, a widely prescribed biologic for inflammatory conditions, has been at the forefront of this transition.¹ However, concerns about biosimilar acceptance persist, leading to varying adoption rates across healthcare settings.²⁻³ Understanding the real-world impact of these transitions is crucial for ensuring the sustainable adoption of biosimilars.

Endpoints

Primary endpoint: Evaluate the rate of biosimilar conversion associated with the exclusion of the adalimumab originator product from a formulary.

Secondary endpoint: Stratify non-biosimilar conversions by diagnosis and drug class to identify insightful trends.

Methods

Study design: Single center, retrospective cohort study at Optum Specialty Pharmacy, exempt from UnitedHealth Group Institutional Review Board. Patients affected by a formulary plan exclusion who previously received adalimumab originator product were followed for up to 9 months after their first therapy conversion to either a biosimilar, an alternative biologic therapy, or continuation with originator product. Patients were stratified by diagnosis to identify factors associated with successful or unsuccessful conversions.

Inclusion criteria: Patients were required to have maintained active insurance through the duration of follow-up.

Data source: Data was collected from a national specialty pharmacy’s prescription database between April 2024 – February 2025.

Statistical analysis: Appropriate descriptive statistical tests were used to evaluate the outcomes.

References

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Disclosures/contact

Authors of this presentation have the following to disclose: Employees; stock holders of UnitedHealth Group. For more information, please contact Optum at clindataenablement@optum.com.

Results

Figure 1. Patient waterfall

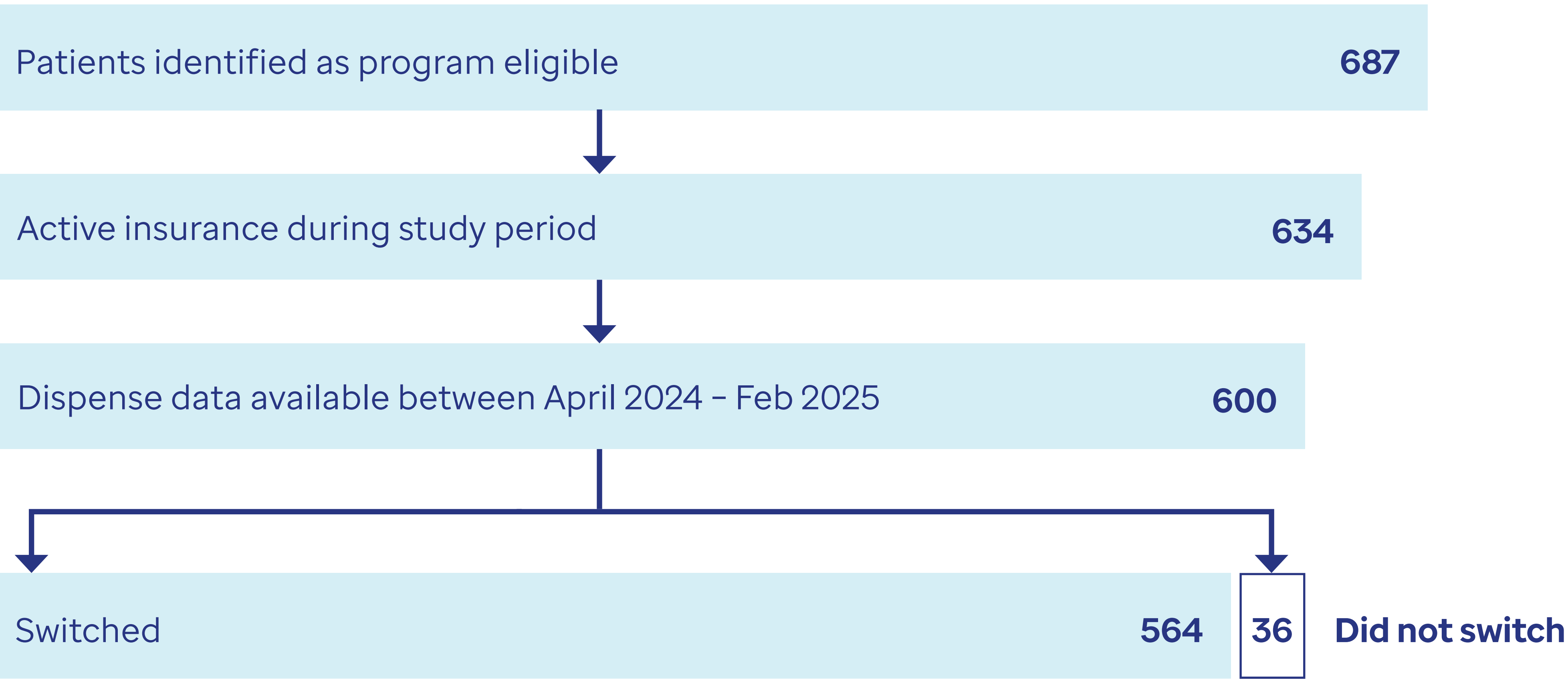
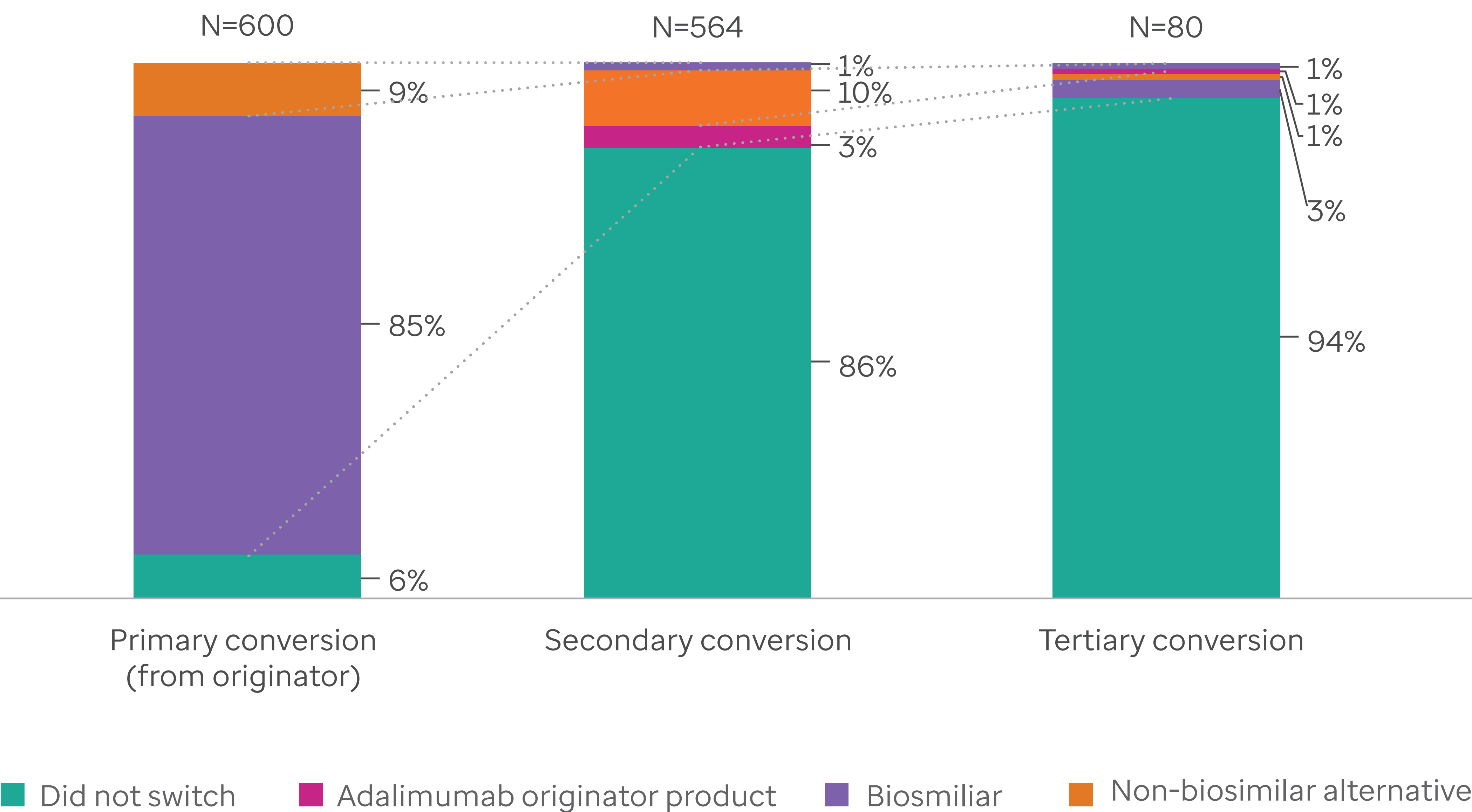


Figure 2. Originator product conversion rates

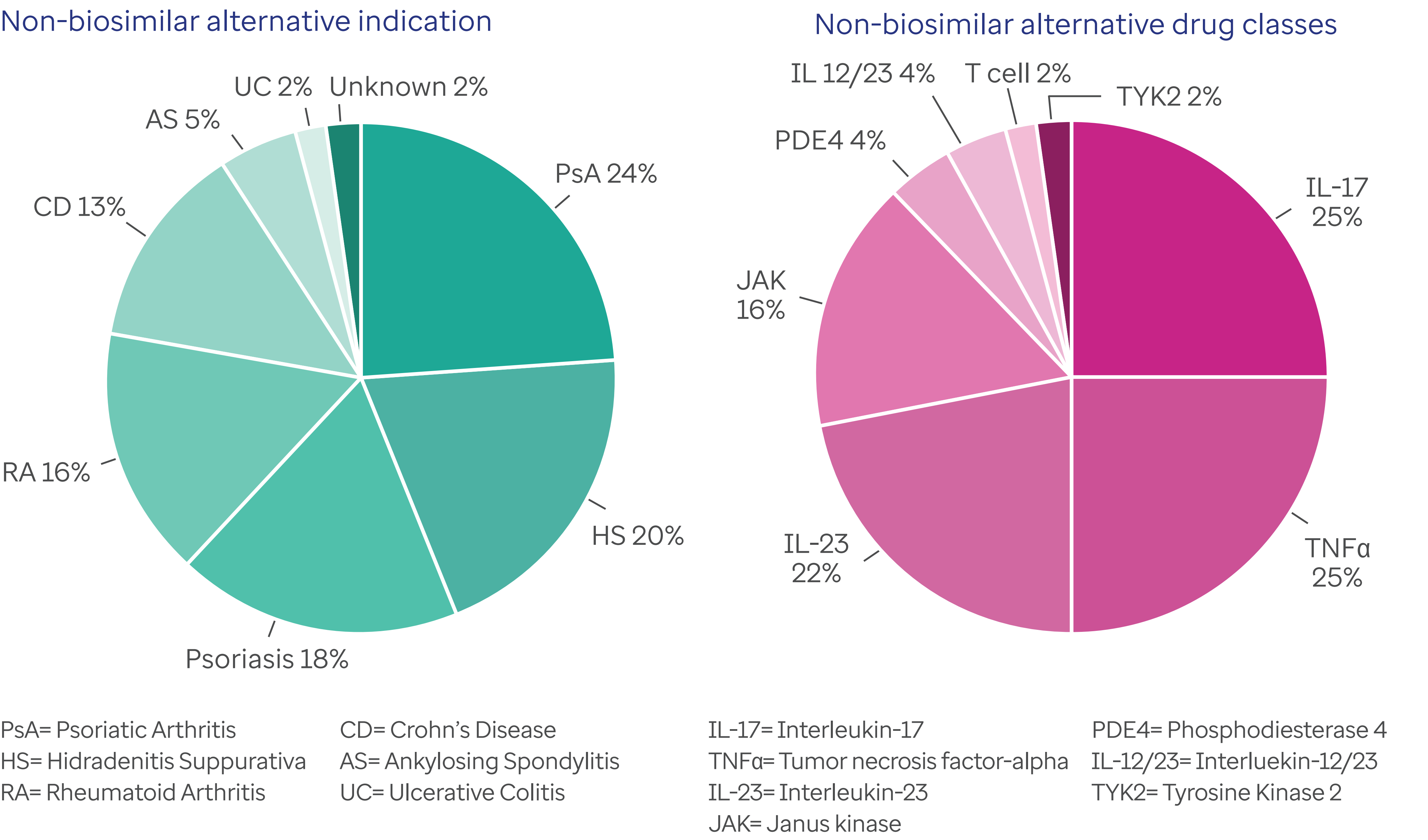
Apr 2024 - Feb 2025 (N=600)

Reversion rate* to adalimumab originator product: 3.4%



*Primary and secondary conversions combined

Figure 3. Primary conversion: Non-biosimilar alternative trends (N=55)



Discussion

- Following a formulary change, 85% of patients successfully transitioned from originator adalimumab to biosimilar, with highest incidence in RA and PsA indications.
- These findings support the continued use of formulary management strategies to optimize biosimilar uptake and inform broader managed care and policy decisions aimed at reducing specialty drug costs while maintaining high-quality patient care.

Limitations

- This study was limited to a single large national specialty pharmacy, which may affect generalizability.
- The follow-up period, while sufficient for short-term analysis, may not capture delayed reversion or treatment discontinuation.
- Data were limited to dispensing records, and clinical outcomes such as disease activity or adverse events were not assessed.

Future considerations

- Further research is warranted to assess longer-term clinical outcomes and continued cost savings. This is planned for a 2026 Optum research project.

